MODULE 5 INSIDER PLAYBOOK - HUMAN FREQUENCY: The Relationship Ladder & Industry Etiquette

Executive insider briefing - confidential

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Executive briefing. The durable layer under the lessons. Read after 5.1-5.4.

THE RELATIONSHIP LADDER (MEMORIZE THE RUNGS)

Rung	Name	Definition	Your move
1	Stranger	No reply, no contact	The pitch
2	Contact	A reply - any reply	Answer fast, offer the call
3	Conversation	A 12-minute call	Listen 3 min, one ask, one next step
4	Ally	An add + thank-you + asset	Thank-you economy
5	Champion	Re-adds, upgrades, introduces you	Value drops, 2-way intros
6	Confidant	Shares feedback, format info, goes to bat	Monthly one-line check-ins, zero asks

The ladder is why Module 5's cadence exists: a call doesn't get you a champion; the year of correct stewardship does. Most artists stall at rung 3 (one call, then nothing) and call radio a closed door.

THE THANK-YOU MATRIX (WHAT LABELS ACTUALLY DO FOR THEIR CHAMPIONS)

- Rung 4 (add): specific 3-day thank-you + social clip tagging the station.
- Rung 5 (upgrade/repeat): 2-week asset (station ID, premiere, reserved tickets) + an on-air shout-out offer.
- Rung 6 (champion): 90-day value drop - no ask attached. Introduce them to an artist. Send a listener for the request line. Give them the story first.

The matrix's rule: the gesture is always one rung above the ask. If you want champion behavior, give confidant respect first. This inversion is the entire economy.

THE 12-MINUTE CALL: THE INSIDER SCRIPT QUEUE

- The warm-up is bait, not small talk. "What's the most exciting thing that's happened on [show] this month?" Their answer is a gift: it tells you exactly what they're proud of - and what to reference forever after.
- The format question is a market scan. "What does a new record need to do to fit here?" The answer contains their internal criteria - their wording - which you can mirror in every future pitch.
- The timing question is a calendar unlock. "When's your add cycle and what day does rotation go out?" Answers set your next campaign's dates.
- The ask is the smallest possible thing. One slot. One show. One recheck date. The call's goal is the next step, not the commitment.

Golden rule: never end a call without a next step and a date. No next step = no relationship. The 12-minute call that ends in a date becomes rung 3 -> rung 4 in 72 hours.

THE INDUSTRY ETIQUETTE CODE (VIOLATIONS THAT BURN WELLS)

- Never pitch another record in the same conversation as a thank-you. The thank-you is its own message. Momentum is not a coupon.
- Never ask a PD for a separate favor (press, playlist, social) in the same ask. Radio owes you one thing per cycle. One ask, one cycle.
- Never argue about a "no." A "not now" is a calendar answer, not a judgment. A polite "understood, checking back in [month]" converts a no into a recheck - which is a win disguised as a rejection.
- Never use the words "sorry to bother you" or "I know you're busy." You're telling the PD their attention is a burden. They know. It's the ask that matters.
- Never send a gift with an ask attached. The gift is the message.
- Never share another artist's private contact or a promo rep's list. The industry is small; leaks travel fast and kill trust permanently.

THE BURNED-WELL TRIAGE (POINTERS FROM THE REPLAY)

- Highest ROI: the well you ghosted (a promise unkept). One honest bridge can recover a full ally in a month.
- High ROI: the well you spammed (blasted, went quiet). 90-day cooling + clean signal + new value. Slow but recoverable.
- Medium ROI: the clash well (pitched a mismatch, argued). Only recover if the format changed or a new MD arrived - check the playlist first.
- Low ROI: the value-debt well (got a yes, gave nothing back). Recover via a genuine giving period - and this one actually improves you: it's a discipline lesson, not a repair.

Never re-pitch a well before its cooling period ends. Never re-pitch with the same angle. Two violations and the well is permanent.

THE INTRO-WEB MULTIPLIER (THE CONFIDANT MOVE)

The highest-value relationship move in the entire system: introduce two of your contacts who benefit each other. The PD gets a useful connection, you get network gravity, and the rung you climb is irrelevant - you become a node of value. Two intros a month builds a confidant network faster than fifty emails. When your next record drops, the intros you made are the credits you've banked.

A PD's time is the only inventory they can't restock - and they notice who respects it. The 12-minute call, the 3-touch stop, the one-ask rule, and the thank-you economy aren't politeness; they're a demonstration that you understand the inventory. That understanding is what makes a PD think of you when a specialty slot opens, a local spot opens, or a new-music hour needs a guest. The relationship isn't the ask. The relationship is the respect for the clock.

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